

90-DAY SOFTWARE TESTING CAREER ROADMAP

Software Testing Glossary

100+ essential QA terms explained simply — your quick-reference companion.

Introduction

This glossary defines the QA terms you will hear daily on the job and in interviews. Each definition is deliberately plain-English so you can learn fast and explain concepts clearly to others.

How to Use It

- Skim it early to build vocabulary; revisit before interviews.
- When you meet a new term at work, find it here and use it correctly.
- Being able to define these clearly is a fast way to sound experienced.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Acceptance Criteria	Conditions a feature must meet to be accepted; the basis for tests.
Ad-hoc Testing	Informal testing with no formal plan, relying on tester intuition.
Agile	Iterative delivery approach with continuous testing and feedback.
Alpha Testing	Early testing by internal staff before external release.
API	Interface allowing systems to communicate; tested below the UI.
API Testing	Validating requests, responses, status codes and data at the API layer.
Assertion	A check in a test that confirms an expected outcome.
Automation Testing	Using scripts/tools to execute tests automatically.
Backlog	Prioritised list of work (stories, tasks, bugs) to be done.
Baseline	An agreed reference version used for comparison.
Beta Testing	Testing by real users before full release.
Black Box Testing	Testing functionality without knowledge of internal code.

Term	Meaning
Boundary Value Analysis	Testing at the edges of input ranges where bugs cluster.
Bug	A defect; behaviour that differs from what is expected.
Bug Report	A structured record of a defect enabling reproduction and fix.
Build	A compiled, deployable version of the software.
CI/CD	Continuous Integration/Delivery; automated build, test and deploy.
Compatibility Testing	Checking behaviour across browsers, devices and OSes.
Coverage	How much of the requirements/code/risk the tests address.
Defect	A flaw in the software causing incorrect behaviour.
Defect Density	Number of defects relative to size (e.g. per module).
Defect Lifecycle	The states a defect moves through from new to closed.
Defect Leakage	Defects that escape a phase and are found later.
Deployment	Releasing a build into an environment.
Dynamic Testing	Testing by executing the software.
End-to-End Testing	Testing a complete workflow across the whole system.
Entry Criteria	Conditions required before a test phase can start.
Environment	A configured system (dev/test/staging/prod) to run software.
Equivalence Partitioning	Grouping inputs that should behave the same and testing one per group.
Exit Criteria	Conditions that must be met to consider testing done.
Exploratory Testing	Simultaneous learning, test design and execution.
Functional Testing	Verifying the software does what it should.
Gherkin	A readable Given/When/Then syntax for BDD scenarios.
Happy Path	The default, successful flow through a feature.
Hotfix	An urgent fix applied directly to production.
Integration Testing	Testing that components work together correctly.
Issue	A general term for a problem, often tracked in a tool.
Jira	A popular tool for tracking work and defects.
Load Testing	Checking behaviour under expected load.
Manual Testing	Testing performed by a person without automation.
Mock	A simulated component used in place of a real dependency.
Negative Testing	Testing with invalid input to confirm correct handling.
Non-Functional Testing	Testing qualities like performance, security, usability.

Term	Meaning
Performance Testing	Assessing speed, responsiveness and stability under load.
Postman	A widely used tool for manual and automated API testing.
Priority	How soon a defect should be fixed (business urgency).
Production	The live environment used by real users.
Regression Testing	Confirming existing features still work after a change.
Release	A version of software made available to users.
Requirement	A statement of what the software should do.
Retesting	Verifying that a specific fixed defect is now resolved.
Risk-Based Testing	Focusing testing effort on the highest-risk areas.
RTM	Requirements Traceability Matrix mapping requirements to tests.
Sanity Testing	A focused check on a specific area after a change.
Scrum	An agile framework with sprints, roles and ceremonies.
Severity	The technical impact of a defect.
Smoke Testing	A quick check that a build is stable enough to test.
SDLC	Software Development Life Cycle; how software is built.
STLC	Software Testing Life Cycle; the testing process.
Sprint	A fixed, short iteration in Scrum (often 1-2 weeks).
Stakeholder	Anyone with an interest in the product or project.
Static Testing	Reviewing artefacts without executing the software.
Stress Testing	Testing beyond normal load to find breaking points.
System Testing	Testing the complete, integrated application.
Test Case	Detailed steps and expected result for one check.
Test Data	The inputs used to execute tests.
Test Environment	The setup in which testing is carried out.
Test Execution	Running tests and recording results.
Test Plan	A document defining scope, approach, schedule and criteria.
Test Scenario	A high-level description of what to test.
Test Strategy	The high-level, long-lived approach to quality.
Test Suite	A collection of related test cases.
Traceability	The ability to link requirements, tests and defects.
UAT	User Acceptance Testing; users confirm fitness for purpose.

Term	Meaning
Usability Testing	Assessing how easy the product is to use.
Use Case	A description of how a user achieves a goal with the system.
User Story	A short requirement from the user perspective.
Validation	Confirming the product meets the user's real need.
Verification	Confirming the product meets its specification.
Version Control	Tracking changes to code (e.g. Git).
Waterfall	A sequential development approach with distinct phases.
White Box Testing	Testing with knowledge of internal code/structure.
Workaround	A temporary way around a defect until it is fixed.
Acceptance Testing	Confirming the system meets acceptance criteria.
Bug Triage	Reviewing defects to decide priority and ownership.
Checklist	A list used to ensure consistent coverage of steps.
Defect Report	See Bug Report; a documented defect.
Edge Case	An unusual input or condition at the limits of behaviour.
Flaky Test	A test that passes and fails inconsistently.
Mind Map	A visual way to brainstorm test ideas.
Page Object Model	An automation pattern that encapsulates page interactions.
Pair Testing	Two people testing together to share insight.
Quality Assurance	Processes that prevent defects and improve quality.
Quality Control	Activities that detect defects in the product.
Root Cause Analysis	Investigating the underlying cause of a defect.
Selector / Locator	How an automated test finds a UI element.
Test Charter	A focused mission for an exploratory session.
Test Coverage	A measure of how much is exercised by tests.
Test Harness	The setup enabling automated test execution.
Defect Age	How long a defect has been open.
Shift Left	Involving testing earlier in the lifecycle.

Common Mistakes

- Confusing verification with validation, or severity with priority.
- Mixing up regression and retesting.
- Using terms loosely — precise language signals professionalism.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Pick five terms a day and practise explaining each in one sentence. Clear definitions are interview gold and build everyday credibility.